

Space-faring legacy

Check out this awesome infographic indicating the distances we've travelled on other planets.
<http://dgit.in/1000SSd>



HTC sees Red

HTC bagged the prestigious red dot design award for its HTC 8X.
<http://dgit.in/11qcws5>

HOW WE TESTED: GAMING

We first had to identify what separates a gaming headset from a regular headset. A pro-gamer needs only one thing and that is precision; the tonal quality, bass or ambience makes not one bit of difference if the audio doesn't reproduce each audio source accurately, be it a "bong" of a notification or the squishy squirt of a zergling being spawned.

The headsets came in two forms, ones that connected via USB only and others that connected via the standard 3.5mm audio jack or an optional USB sound card. The USB-only devices were tested as is, by directly plugging them into a USB port on the PC, the 3.5mm ones were powered via an ASUS Xonar Phoebus sound card. In both sets, we were looking for the best gaming headset.

Our test rig is as follows:

- Intel Core i7 875K
- 4GB DDR3 RAM
- Nvidia GeForce GTX 560 Ti
- ASUS Xonar Phoebus sound card

Gaming tests

These were considered to be the more important tests of this category and thus, have a weightage of 80%.

For the gaming tests we used the following games:

- **Dead Space 3:** This game has great ambience and detail. We played the prologue and listened for the sounds of beeping in the cockpit, the

whistling of the snow, the positioning of falling debris, etc.

- **Crysis 3:** A beast of a game that is as spectacular sonically as it is graphically. We played the first two levels hearing the patter of rain drops, the echoes of gunshots, radio chatter and positioning accuracy.
- **Quake 3:** A game where stereo sound rules and where every little sound, be it the sound of a rocket whizzing by your head or the sound of someone swiping the mega-health needs to be accurately reproduced.
- **Starcraft 2:** This game is ideal for these headsets as the environment is filled with minor aural clues that are critical to a good multiplayer game.

Multimedia tests

These tests are meant to test the capability of the headsets in areas other than gaming. The weightage for these scores were limited to just 20% though.

These tests included the following:

- Music playback (Angel, Time and Bones)
- Frequency sweeps (20-21000 Hz)
- Movie tests (Saving Private Ryan)

Features were rated based on their importance and what we would expect from a gaming headset. These include factors such as braided cables or extra control buttons, etc. Weights were given according to the importance of the feature and final scores were calculated in relation to the ideal score.

you gangstas, we kid, we kid. As for the performance the headphones deliver brilliant dynamic range – you'll hear everything from the quietest clink of an idiophone instrument, to the loudest scream of a wailing guitar. We heard a rendition of Moonlight Sonata by E.S. Posthumus on these and the experience was ethereal. This might seem exaggerated but there's no other word for it. They're so good one of the reviewers swore to have experienced synesthesia. Obviously, the HD 700 wins our Best Performer award.

Blaupunkt Style

With a funky design and tons of features up its sleeves, this headphone is definitely a conversation piece. It goes head to head with the Ferrari R200 in terms of form factor and cupping design – both are supra



Blaupunkt Style

aural. The moment you put it on you are hit by the sharp sound signature. The vocals sound recessed almost like they're echoing from a large hall. While the Blaupunkt renders highs better, the R200 is more refined. Plus this one is a little too bass heavy for our taste but we're pretty sure it's going to be a hit with bass junkies. Though the headphone is not free of flaws. We can't exactly pin point which fre-



Sennheiser HD 700

fect false mono right in front of you, the sound on the T350 spatially appears to be originating from where the transducers are placed – right next to your ears. The mid-range is not quite as

open as the HD 700 and the overpowering bass obscures other details. But before you think we're bashing these cans understand this – they're extremely detailed, and just the fact that we can compare them to the HD 700 is testament to their aural finesse. Anyone looking for great audio along with a bit of brand fuelled panache should seriously consider them.

Sennheiser HD 700

By now you must surely be curious about these cans considering the very high pedestal we've already raised them to. Well your curiosity is justified and the HD 700 will not disappoint. From the moment you hold them in your hand you know right away you're going

to be privy to something great. The ear cups are open and the grille mesh on the outside is specifically designed to direct control the flow of air and reduce harmonic distortion. Of course they provide virtually no isolation but the sound quality is superlative. The overall sound is almost sparkly and so open, you get a brilliant wide soundstage. Vocal performance does not take a beating even when the instrument density is high. They are neutral and that for most people means bass shy. Which is why they work for most genres of music except perhaps hiphop and dubstep. But well if you're the prospective owner of an HD 700 you're probably someone who steers clear of those genres anyway. Calm down all